

technocrat and communications manager of IM, and Akbar Chaudhary, brother of Mohsin Chaudhary, all lodged in Sabarmati Jail in Ahmedabad in connection with the serial blasts in the city. Both of them had a strong base in Pune. In fact, nine out of the 47 accused arrested in connection with the Ahmedabad serial

in Mumbai. A similar combination was also used in the subsequent chain blasts in Malegaon on September 8, 2006. The security agencies, so far, were still not sure about how the blast had been triggered since they failed to recover any remnants of a timer device. Sources said that the packing of explosives was of such high quality that even forensic experts found it difficult to find any clue about its timer. However, presence of pieces of a mobile phone among the debris had brought experts to examine whether the bombs were triggered by remote

Centre and the state have been talking in the same voice and have desisted from the usual blame-game. The Maharashtra Government has echoed the Home Ministry's claim that there was no intelligence failure. Sources in the Home Ministry admitted there had been specific intelligence input about Osho Ashram and Chabad House and a general alert for Pune, which is among the fastest growing cities in the country. A senior Home Ministry official says that for a city on the terror radar, the level of alertness should have been more. The local police received flak for being preoccupied in providing security to cinema halls for screening of *My*



(LEFT) GERMAN BAKERY, THE BLAST SITE; (BELOW) GRIEVING RELATIVES OF A GIRL KILLED IN THE EXPLOSION



Combination of RDX, ammonium nitrate and petroleum hydrocarbon oil.

blasts were from Pune. The suspicion is that following the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks and the strengthened vigilance in the city, the IM had shifted the bulk of its operations to Pune.

Investigators claim to have substantial evidence from the explosives used in the German Bakery blast on February 13 that killed 11 and injured 60. The explosive was a deadly combination of RDX, ammonium nitrate and petroleum hydrocarbon oil. Packed in a backpack and left under a table, it was the same cocktail used in the July 11, 2006 serial train blasts

using the cellphone. The investigators were also verifying if a part of the RDX recovered from Aurangabad in May, 2008, was used in the Pune blast. The security agencies had recovered 43 kg of RDX, 16 AK-47 assault rifles, 50 Chinese-made grenades and over 3,200 rounds from Aurangabad. Sources in intelligence agencies tracking old cases claimed that case records reveal that there was a clear triangle as far as the Aurangabad arms haul case, 7/11 Mumbai blasts and Malegaon case were concerned.

In a departure from the past, the

Name is Khan. But Additional Chief Secretary, Home, Chandra Iyengar denies that the police was caught off-guard. "The security that is needed for vital installations is independent of other police work such as crowd control and this does not get touched." She adds that police across Maharashtra had been working with sensitive soft targets such as malls, religious centres and multiplexes to boost their internal security.

For Pune residents, last Saturday's blast was a grim reminder that they cannot afford to lower their guard. ■